While Col Agarwal was on leave, I officiated as the CO. 8 SIKH LI is an excellent Battalion with well-laid-out SOPs. Moreover, Col Agarwal had fine-tuned it even more. I really did not have to do much, except to keep ensuring the standards that he had set. During this period, we were visited by the GOC 4 Corps, Lt Gen DB Shekatkar. This was the first time I would be briefing anyone so senior and I went over each and every aspect of the unit: operations, training, administration, finances, leaving no stone unturned, especially since 8 SIKH LI was relatively new to me. The briefing went off well (I think) and the Corps Commander asked me if I had any recommendations. Emboldened by his quiet and unassuming manner, I told him that this shifting of the unit every three months or so was affecting us adversely, both operationally and administratively. Operationally, we were unable to produce results because, by the time we settled down, got to know the terrain and developed some sources, we were packed off to some new location. Administratively, we were not given our due, not because no one wanted to, but by the time our projections were made and considered, we would have moved out. Gen Shekatkar saw the merit and logic in my arguments and asked his staff officer to make a note of it. Col Agarwal returned from leave shortly thereafter, and along with him came our next move order—back to Kathiatali!

Apparently, we had been moved out considering the area South of Nagaon to be dormant and the area was handed over to an Engineer Regiment. Some officers of this Regiment tried to do some undercover operation which backfired and they were both shot dead at point-blank range in the marketplace of one of the interior villages. It was several hours before anyone even came to know of such an incident, that too, through police channels. Hence, this order to move back

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